Harmony

Chords, inversions, and accompanying a melody.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

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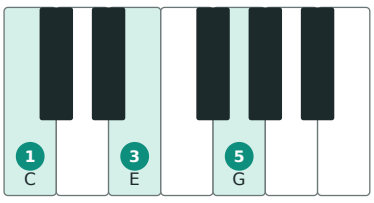
1. Your first chord

Three notes at once: the C major triad.

Stacking skips

A **chord** is several notes played together. The most common chord is a **triad**: three notes, each a skip apart. Start on C, skip to E, skip to G: that's the **C major chord**.

The bottom note, C, is the **root** and gives the chord its name.

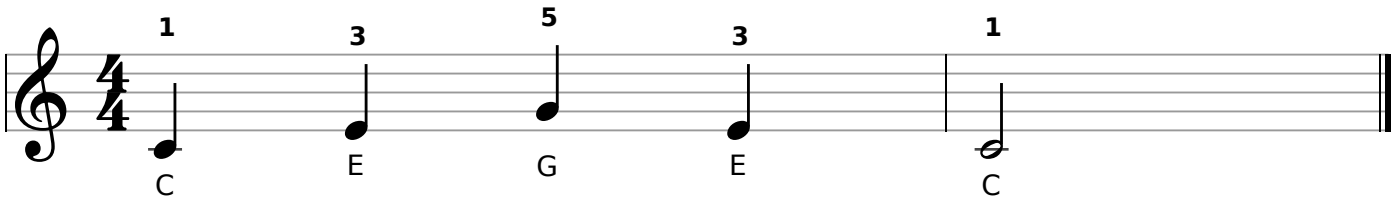


C major chord: C E G, fingers 1 3 5

Figure 6.1 · Stacking skips

Practise · Broken chord first

Play the three notes one at a time: C, E, G. Then back down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · All together

Now press C, E and G at exactly the same time, fingers 1 3 5. Land like a soft cat, all three together.

About listening for chords

Chords are much harder for a phone to hear than single notes. If the app is slow to accept a chord, try playing the notes quickly one after another (a "rolled" chord), or tap the keys on screen.

Practise · Left hand chord

Left hand: C E G below Middle C, fingers 5 3 1.

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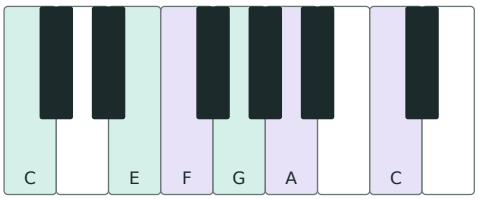
2. C, F and G chords

The three chords behind thousands of songs.

Three families

Build the same skip-skip shape on **F** and you get F A C, the **F major chord**. Build it on **G**: G B D, the **G major chord**.

C, F and G are the most important chords in the key of C. Musicians call them **I**, **IV** and **V** (one, four and five), because C, F and G are the 1st, 4th and 5th notes of the C scale.

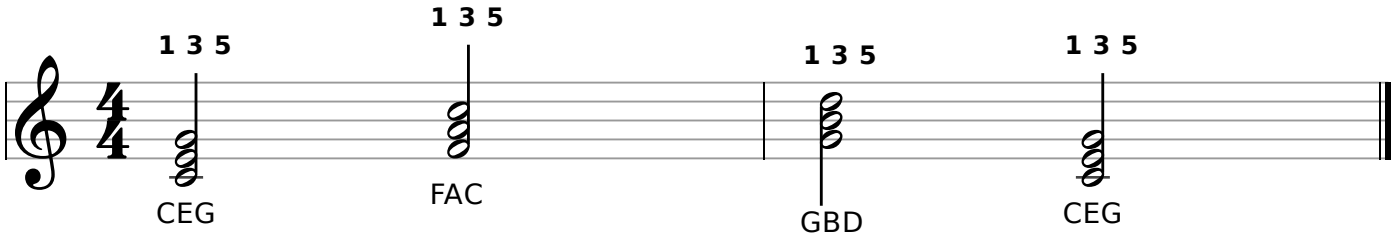


C chord (C E G) and F chord (F A C)

Figure 6.2 · Three families

Practise · Moving the chord shape

Play C chord, F chord, G chord, then C chord. Keep the hand shape and slide it along.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand chord shapes

Same thing with the left hand, fingers 5 3 1.

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3. Rock of Ages

A hymn in 3/4 over C, F and G chords.

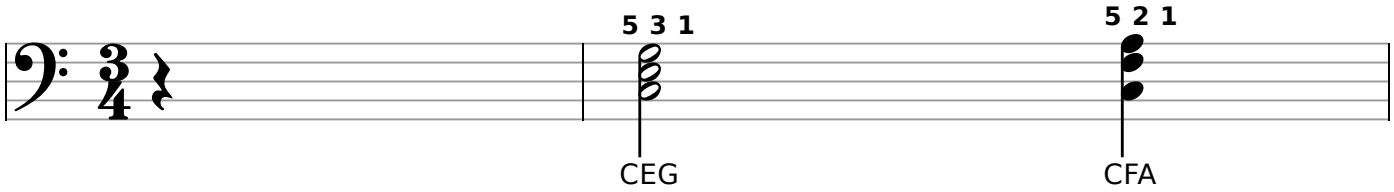
Melody over chords

Augustus Toplady wrote **Rock of Ages** in 1776, and Thomas Hastings's tune followed in 1830. The melody goes in your right hand. The left hand plays the **C, F and G chords** you just learned.

It's in 3/4 with a short pickup, two eighth notes on beat 3.

Practise · Left hand chords

Mostly C, with G and F where the melody needs them.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Rock of Ages, hands together

Melody a little louder than the chords.

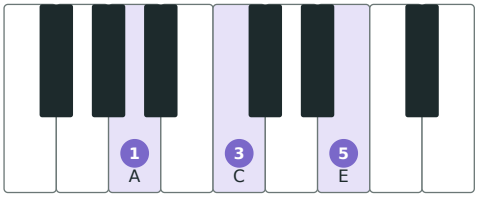
4. Minor chords

A minor, D minor and E minor.

Same shape, different colour

The white-key chord built on **A** is A C E. It has the same skip-skip shape, but it sounds **minor**, darker than C major.

The white-key chords on **D** (D F A) and **E** (E G B) are minor too. Major or minor depends on where the middle note sits.

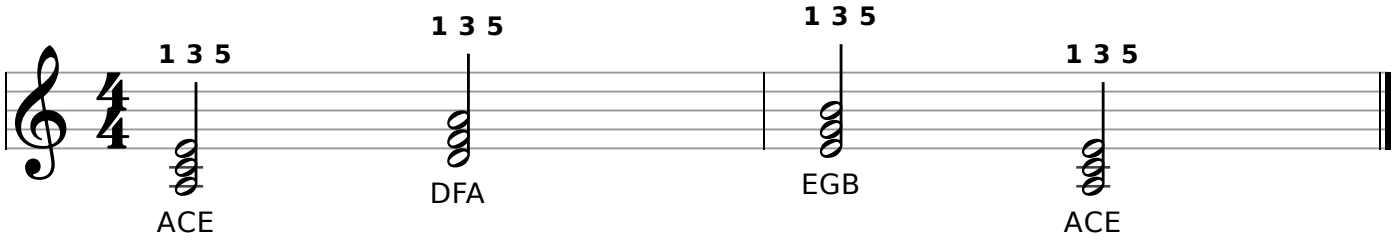


A minor chord: A C E

Figure 6.3 · Same shape, different colour

Practise · Minor chords

Play A minor, D minor, E minor, then A minor again. Listen to the mood.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Major chord or minor chord?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Minor D F A is D minor.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Major F A C is F major.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> One more.
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Minor E G B is E minor.

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5. Inversions

Rearranging a chord so it moves smoothly.

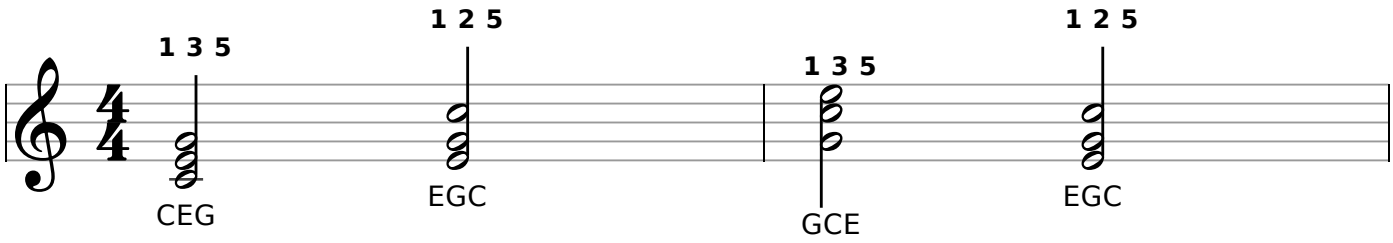
Same notes, new order

A chord doesn't have to have its root on the bottom. Move the bottom C up an octave and you get **E G C**: still a C chord, called **first inversion**. Move E up too and you get **G C E**, **second inversion**.

Inversions let your hand stay in one place while the chords change. That sounds smoother and is much easier.

Practise · C chord inversions

Root position, first inversion, second inversion, and back.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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6. Chord progressions

I, IV, V, I with smooth voicing.

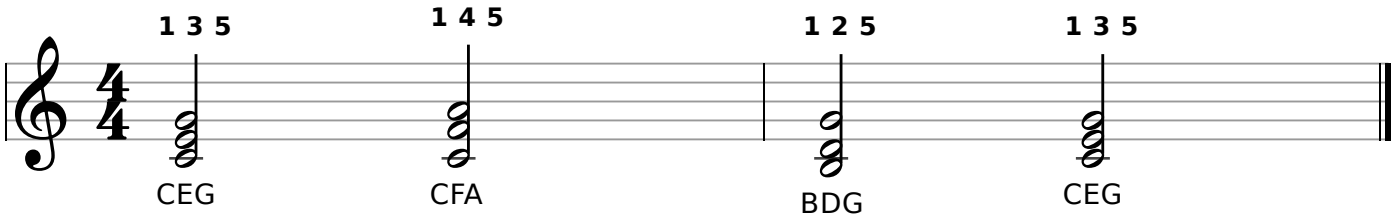
A chord journey

A **progression** is a series of chords. **C, F, G, C** (I IV V I) is the backbone of countless pieces.

Using inversions, the right hand barely moves: **C E G → C F A → B D G → C E G**. The left hand plays just the root of each chord.

Practise · Right hand only

Watch how one or two fingers move each time, and the rest stay still.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Hands together

Add the left-hand roots: C, F, G, C.

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7. Doxology with chords

The melody over left-hand C, F and G chords.

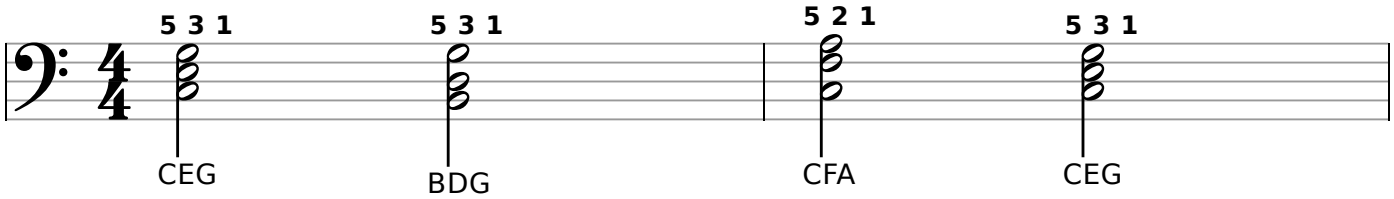
Adding harmony

Now the left hand can play **chords** under the melody, two to a bar, using the three you know: **C, F and G**.

The right hand moves up an octave, to the C above Middle C, so the hands don't bump into each other.

Practise · Left hand chords alone

Line one's chords: C, G, F, C, G, C. Keep them soft and even.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 1 and 2, hands together

Melody a little louder than the chords. Change chord on beats 1 and 3.

Practise · Lines 3 and 4, hands together

The same idea for the second half.

Practise · The whole hymn with chords

All four lines, melody over chords.

8. 'Tis So Sweet to Trust in Jesus

A hymn in G over G, C and D chords.

Chords in G

Louisa Stead's words (1882) and William Kirkpatrick's tune make one of the best-loved gospel hymns. It's in **G major**, and the left hand plays **G, C and D** chords: the same I, IV, V journey you just learned, in a new key.

The chords hold for a whole bar or half a bar, so your left hand has time to move.

Practise · Left hand chords

G stays under finger 5 except for the D chord.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · 'Tis So Sweet, hands together

Verse and refrain.

9. Broken chords and Alberti bass

The classical way to accompany a melody.

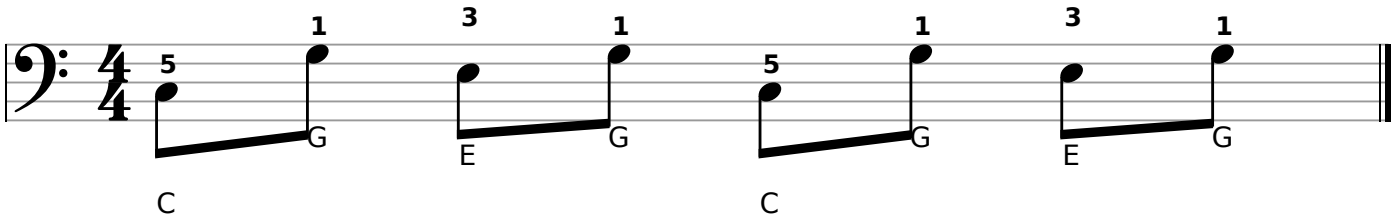
Alberti bass

Classical composers like Mozart and Haydn often break the left-hand chord into a rocking pattern: **bottom, top, middle, top**. It's called **Alberti bass**, after Domenico Alberti.

For a C chord: **C G E G**, fingers **5 1 3 1**. Keep it light and even, with the thumb barely touching its key.

Practise · Alberti on C

Left hand: C G E G, over and over. Smooth and soft.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Changing chords

Now move through C, F (C A F A), G (B G D G) and back to C.

Practise · Melody over Alberti

Right hand holds long notes while the left hand rocks underneath.

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10. Pachelbel's Canon chords

The most famous chord progression in classical music.

Eight chords on repeat

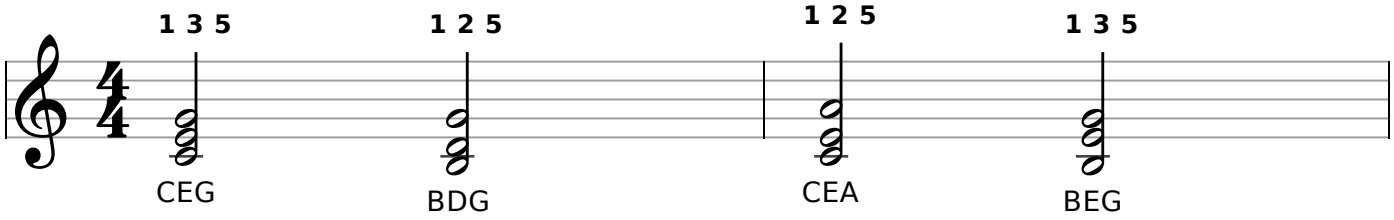
Johann Pachelbel's **Canon** (around 1700) repeats the same eight chords again and again while melodies weave over the top. Here it is moved to C major:

C – G – Am – Em – F – C – F – G

Right hand plays close inversions so it barely moves. The left hand plays the roots, mostly downward.

Practise · Right hand chords

Each chord lasts two beats. Move as few fingers as you can.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand roots

Left hand: C G A E F C F G.

Practise · The Canon progression

Hands together. Take your time between chords; the app waits.

11. 6/8 time

Six quick beats, felt as two big ones.

Two big beats

In **6/8** time there are six eighth notes in each bar, grouped in threes: "**1** 2 3 **4** 5 6". It feels like **two big beats**, each split into three. That gives it a gentle rocking or rolling feel.

A **dotted quarter note** fills one big beat (three eighths), and a **dotted half note** fills the whole bar. Silent Night, coming up in your recital, is in 6/8.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Does this rock in twos (6/8) or march in fours (4/4)?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Rocks in two (6/8) You can hear the long-short groups of three. That lilt is 6/8.

Practise · Row, Row, Row Your Boat

Count "1 2 3 4 5 6" in each bar. In "merrily, merrily", move your hand freely to reach the high C.



Opening example · 6/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

12. Greensleeves

An English tune from the 1500s, in 6/8 and E minor.
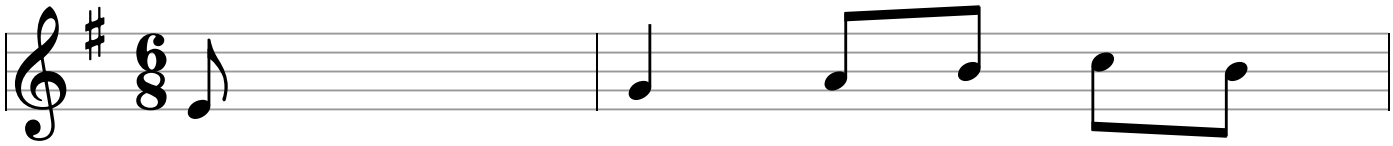
Greensleeves

Greensleeves is an English tune from the 16th century. Churches sing it at Christmas as "What Child Is This". It's in **6/8** and **E minor**.

It starts with a one-eighth pickup on E. Look for the sharps: F♯ from the key, and D♯ and C♯ near the end of each line.

Practise · Greensleeves

Two big beats per bar, each split into three.



Opening example · 6/8 · Em · finger 1 = thumb

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13. Pop Goes the Weasel

A bouncy 6/8 dance tune, with a repeat.

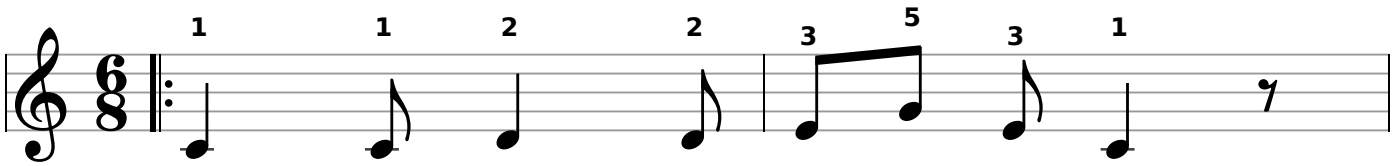
A jig

Pop Goes the Weasel was a popular dance tune in the 1850s. It's a **jig**, in 6/8, with a long-short bounce: quarter note, eighth note.

The "Pop!" is the high A. Play the whole tune twice: it's inside repeat signs.

Practise · Pop Goes the Weasel

Bouncy. Make the "Pop!" loud and short.



Opening example · 6/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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14. Silent Night

Melody with left-hand chords, in gentle 6/8 time.

Silent Night

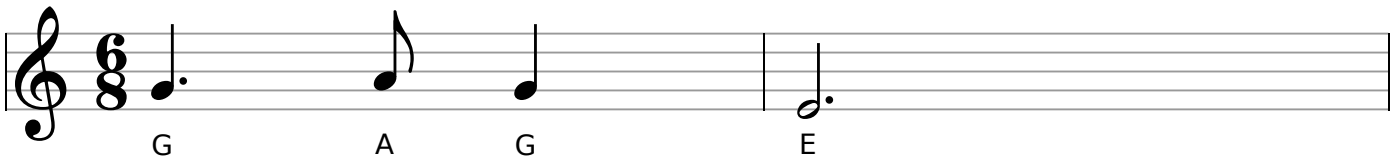
Franz Xaver **Gruber** wrote this melody for a Christmas Eve service in Oberndorf, Austria, in **1818**, with words by Joseph Mohr.

It's in **6/8**: six eighth notes per bar, felt as two slow, swaying beats. Count "**1** 2 3 **4** 5 6".

The left hand plays just **three chords** you already know: **C** (C E G), **F** (C F A) and **G** (B D G), one chord per bar, held long.

Practise · Melody, first half

"Silent night, holy night, all is calm, all is bright…"



Opening example · 6/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Melody, second half

"Round yon virgin… Holy infant… Sleep in heavenly peace."

Practise · Left-hand chords

Left hand alone: C, G and F chords. Move as little as you can between them.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

Hands together, with hints. Each chord lands with the first melody note of its bar.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

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15. O Come, O Come, Emmanuel

An ancient, haunting hymn in E minor.

O Come, O Come, Emmanuel

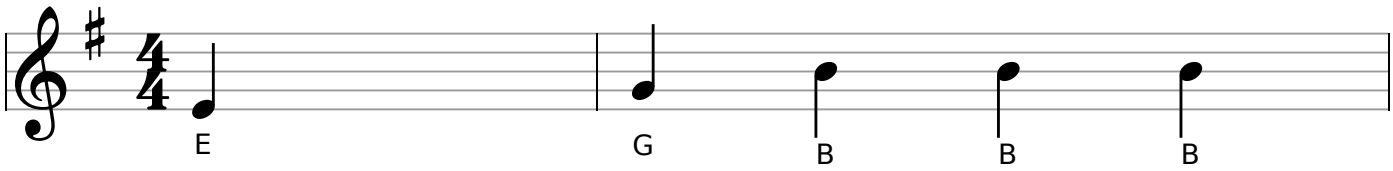
This melody comes from a **15th-century** French chant book. John Mason Neale's English words were joined to it in 1851.

It's in **E minor**, which gives it its dark, longing sound. E minor shares its key signature with G major: one sharp, **F**♯.

Play it smoothly (**legato**), like singing. Every line but the first starts with a one-beat pickup, and the refrain begins high on D: "Rejoice! Rejoice!"

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

"O come, O come, Emmanuel, and ransom captive Israel…"



Opening example · 4/4 · Em · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 3 and 4

"That mourns in lonely exile here, until the Son of God appear."

Practise · The refrain

"Rejoice! Rejoice! Emmanuel shall come to thee, O Israel."

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole hymn, with hints. Keep it smooth and unhurried.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Build and recognize the major and minor triads introduced here.
- ☐ Move between root-position chords and inversions.
- ☐ Play the chord progression and accompaniment patterns slowly and evenly.
- ☐ Count 6/8 in two groups of three and keep the melody clear above the accompaniment.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
